

Commitment to Singlehood:

*Testing measurement
invariance across groups*

Tara Bello
Syracuse University
tmbello@syr.edu





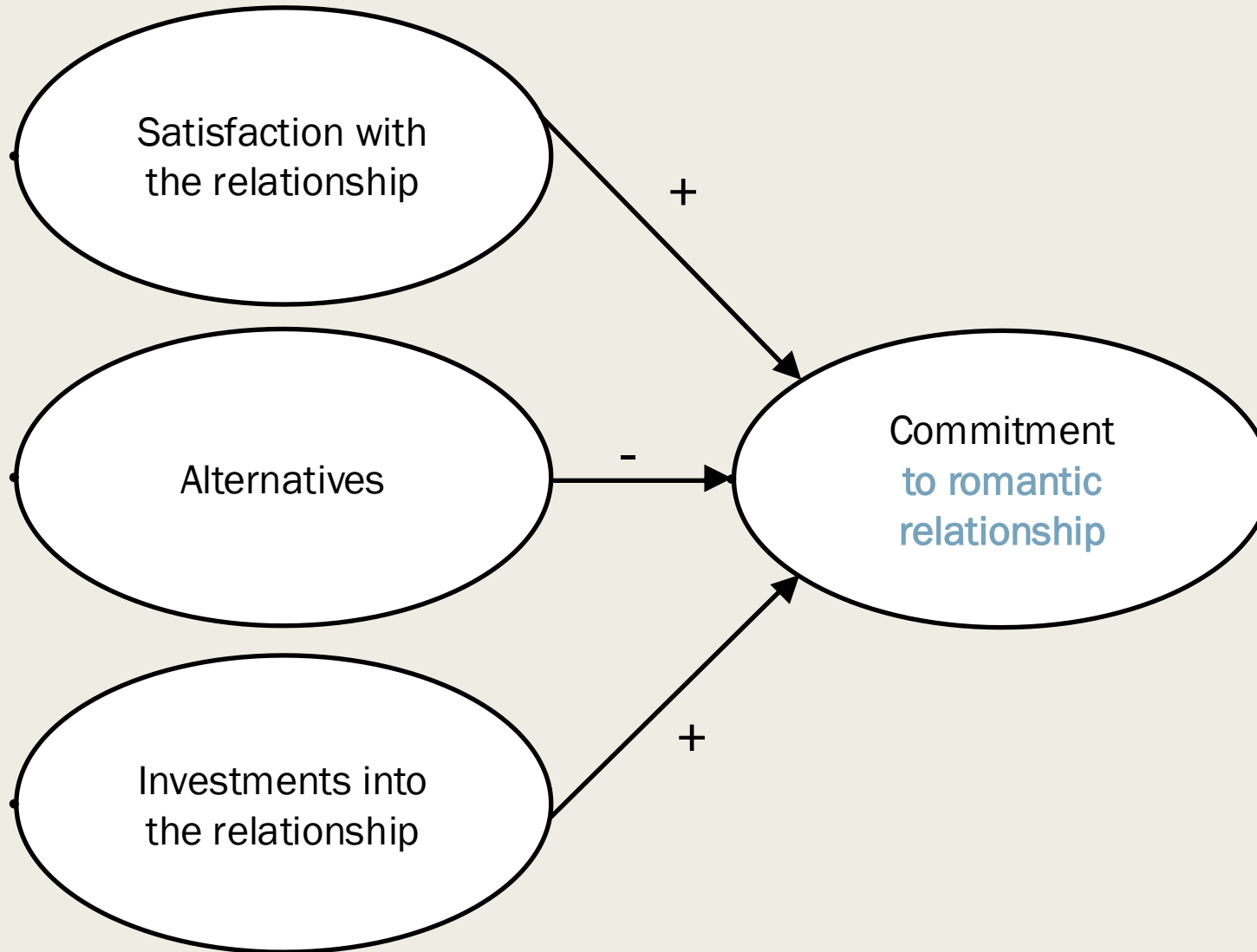
Can people be committed to remaining single in the same way they commit to these things?

If so, who is more or less committed to being single?



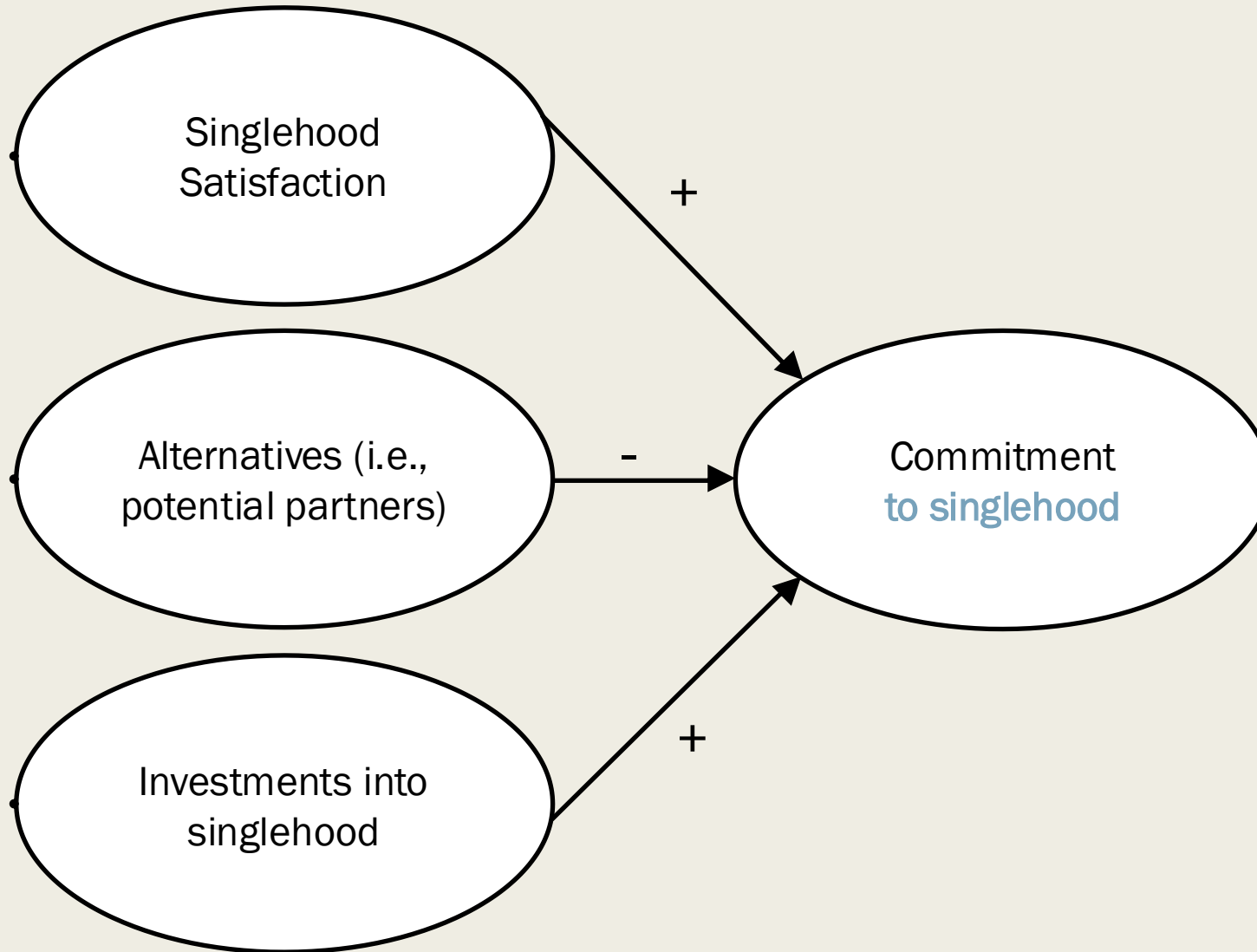
Commitment is the intention to persist or remain dedicated **to a person, cause, or activity.**

Can people be committed to remaining single in the same way they commit to these things?

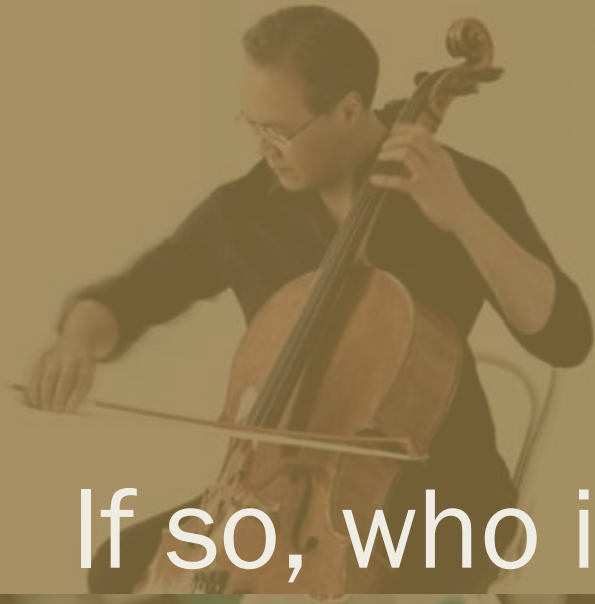


Investment Model
of Commitment
applied to
***romantic
relationships***
(Rusbult, 1980)

Can people be committed to remaining single in the same way they commit to these things?

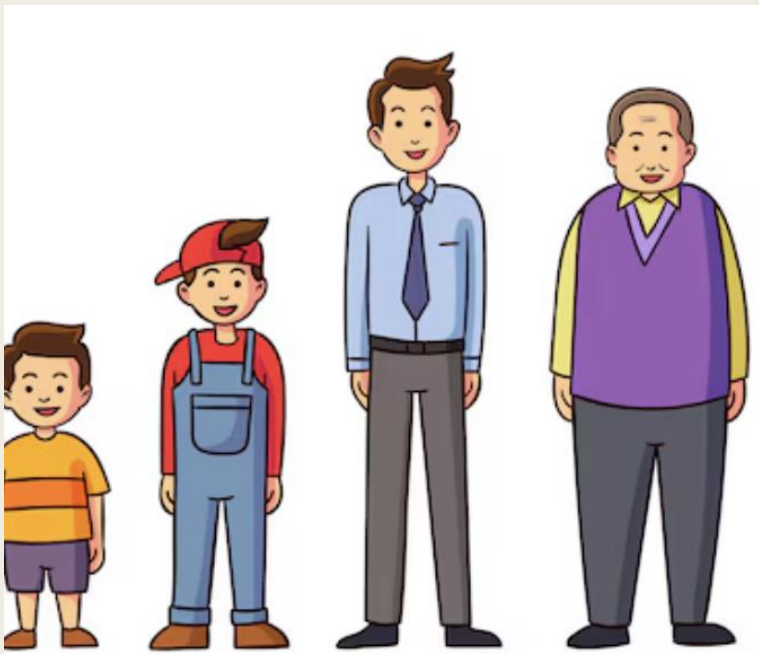


Investment Model
of Commitment
applied to
singlehood
(Beauparlant,
2023)



If so, who is more or less committed to being single?

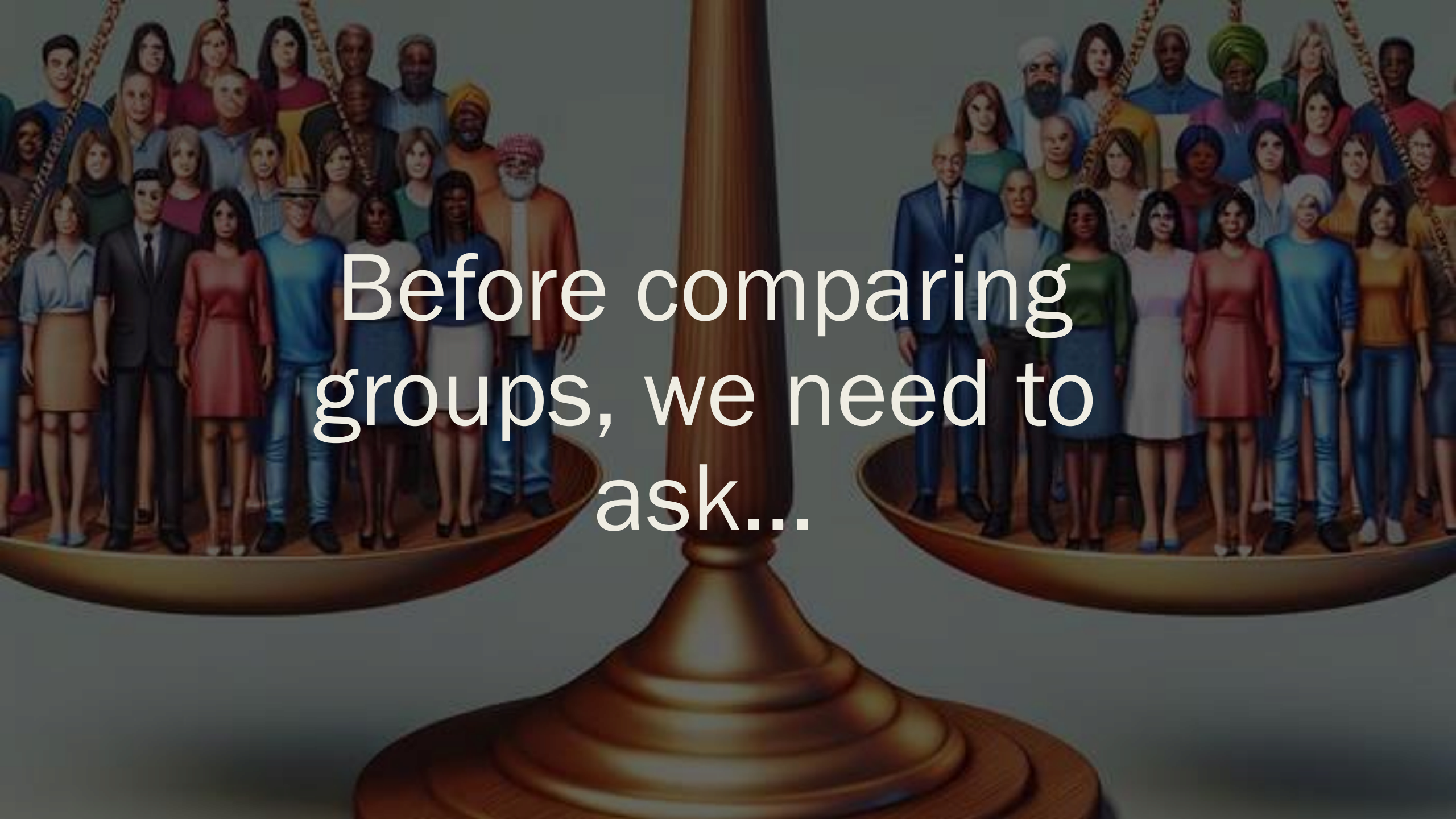




Singlehood experiences can vary by gender, age, political orientation, relationship history (Apostolou et al, 2020; Fangmeier et al., 2020; Oh et al., 2021; Park et al., 2022)



Thus, there may be differences in commitment to singlehood across these characteristics.

A large group of diverse people, including men and women of various ages and ethnicities, are standing on the two pans of a large, ornate brass balance scale. The scale is positioned in the center of the frame, with its base and central column visible. The people are arranged in several rows, filling both pans. The background is a solid, muted blue-grey color. The text "Before comparing groups, we need to ask..." is overlaid in the center of the image, in a white, sans-serif font.

Before comparing
groups, we need to
ask...

Measurement invariance refers to the extent to which a scale or questionnaire measures the same construct in the same way across different groups





Research Questions

1. Can we establish invariance of commitment and its predictors across gender, age, political orientation, and relationship history?
2. If invariance is established, how do individuals different on singlehood satisfaction, investments, alternatives, and commitment across these socio-demographic characteristics?



Sample Descriptives

$N = 705$ single participants

- Collected from prolific in Fall 2024 ($N = 326$) and Summer 2025 ($N = 379$)
- $M_{age} = 37.20$ (18-77 years)
- 49.8% Men, 48.1% Female, 2.1% other
- 74.3% straight/heterosexual
- 59.9% white
- Additional dataset will be collected in Fall 2025 ($N = 500$)

Investment model scale for singles (IMS-S)

(Beauparlant et al.,
2024)

Satisfaction, Alternatives Investments

I feel satisfied with being single. (S)

Being single is much better than others' relationships. (S)

Being single is close to ideal. (S)

Investment model scale for singles (IMS-S)

(Beauparlant et al.,
2024)

Satisfaction, Alternatives, Investments

I feel satisfied with being single. (S)

Being single is much better than others' relationships. (S)

Being single is close to ideal. (S)

The people I might become involved with are very appealing. (A)

Dating is appealing to me. (A)

For me, being in a relationship would be an attractive alternative to being single. (A)

Investment model scale for singles (IMS-S)

(Beauparlant et al.,
2024)

Satisfaction, Alternatives, Investments

I feel satisfied with being single. (S)

Being single is much better than others' relationships. (S)

Being single is close to ideal. (S)

The people I might become involved with are very appealing. (A)

Dating is appealing to me. (A)

For me, being in a relationship would be an attractive alternative to being single. (A)

I have put a great deal into my single lifestyle that I would lose if I were to start a relationship. (I)

Many aspects of my life have become linked to being single (recreational activities, etc.), and I would lose all of this if I were to start a relationship with someone. (I)

My relationship with friends and family would be complicated if I were to start dating someone (e.g., being single is an important part of my friendships). (I)

Investment model scale for singles (IMS-S)

(Beauparlant et al.,
2024)

Satisfaction, Alternatives, Investments

I feel satisfied with being single. **(S)**

Being single is much better than others' relationships. **(S)**

Being single is close to ideal. **(S)**

The people I might become involved with are very appealing. **(A)**

Dating is appealing to me. **(A)**

For me, being in a relationship would be an attractive alternative to being single. **(A)**

I have put a great deal into my single lifestyle that I would lose if I were to start a relationship. **(I)**

Many aspects of my life have become linked to being single (recreational activities, etc.), and I would lose all of this if I were to start a relationship with someone. **(I)**

My relationship with friends and family would be complicated if I were to start dating someone (e.g., being single is an important part of my friendships). **(I)**

Commitment to Singlehood

I am committed to being single.

I feel very attached to being single -- very strongly linked to my single lifestyle.

I am oriented towards the long-term future of being single (for example, I imagine being single several years from now).

I intend to stay single.

Socio-demographic Groups

Gender: Male (i.e., $n = 351$) vs. Female ($n = 339$)

Age: Young adults (i.e., ages 18-39; $n = 426$) vs. Middle+ adults (i.e., ages 40-77; $n = 278$)

Number of previous relationships: Few (i.e., 1-3; $n = 177$) vs. Many (i.e., 4+; $n = 156$)

Political orientation: Liberal ($n = 487$) vs. Conservative ($n = 218$)

Analysis procedure for MI

- Conduct CFA for the factor structure
 - $CFI > .90$, $RMSEA < .06$, $SRMR < .08$
- Follow the free baseline approach:
 1. Configural (same factor structure)
 2. Weak (equal factor loadings)
 3. Strong (equal intercepts)
 4. Strict (equal residuals)
- Small changes between models (e.g., $\Delta CFI \geq -0.01$; $\Delta RMSEA \geq .015$; $\Delta SRMR \geq .0.030$) support invariance (Chen, 2007)

Table 2. Measurement Invariance across Groups

Commitment				
Groups	Configural	Weak	Strong	Strict
Gender	✓	▲	✓	✓
Age	✓	✓	▲	▲
Relationship History	✓	✓	✓	✓
Political	✓	✓	✓	✓
Satisfaction, Alternatives, Investment				
Gender	✓	✓	X	▲
Age	✓	✓	▲	✓
Relationship History	✓	✓	✓	✓
Political	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note. ✓ = the more constrained model fit significantly worse. ▲ = only Δ SRMR exceeded the cutoff. X = multiple model fit indices exceeded cutoffs, i.e., the more constrained model fit significantly worse.

Figure 1. Group difference in commitment and its predictors

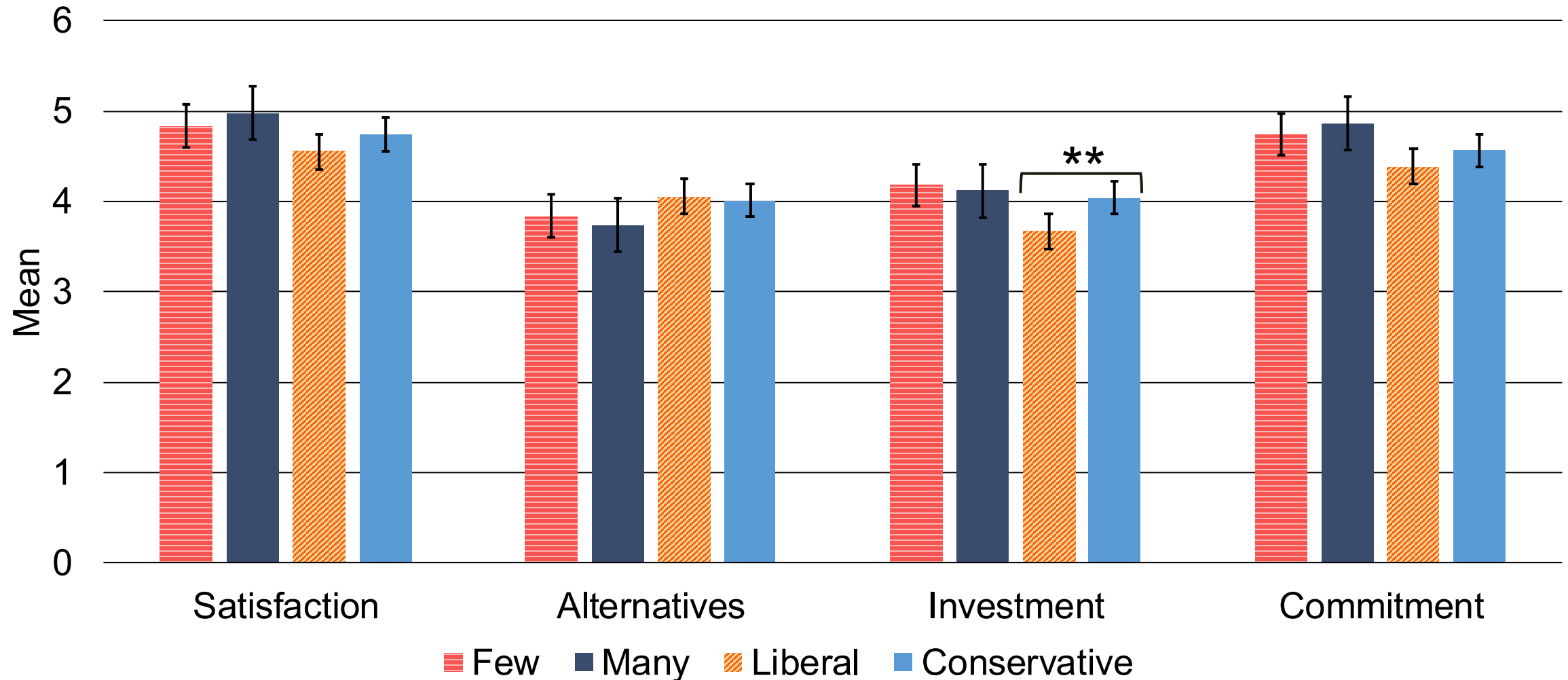
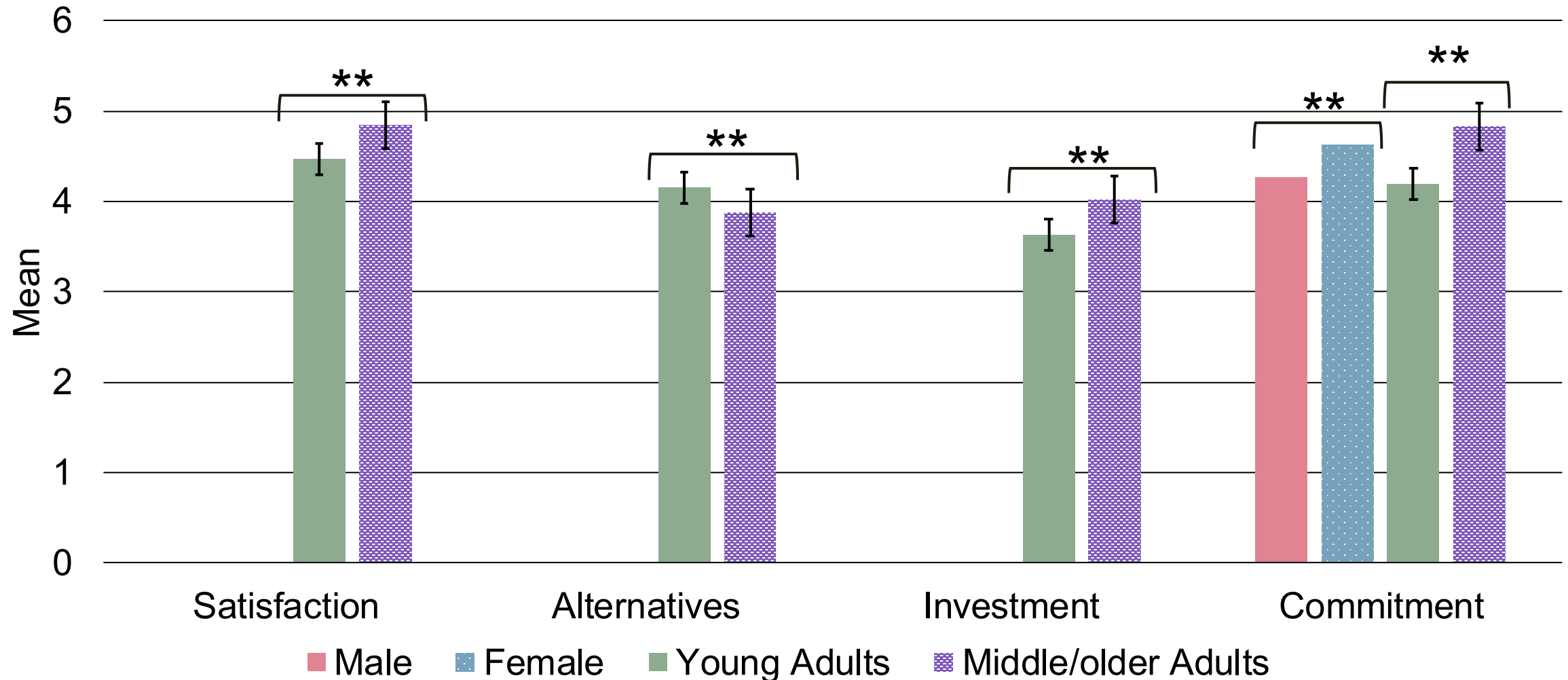


Figure 2. Age and gender differences across commitment and it predictors



Summary of Preliminary findings

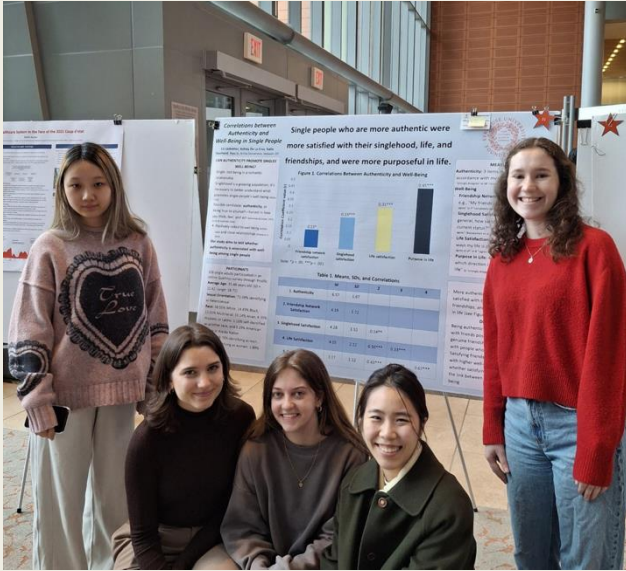
- Measurement invariance results:
 - Evidence of invariance across relationship history and political orientation
 - Somewhat lack of evidence for invariance across age and gender (*only $\Delta SRMR$ exceeds cutoffs*)
- Group difference in commitment and its predictors:
 - Middle/older adults report greater singlehood satisfaction, alternative, investment, and commitment compared to young adults
 - Females report greater commitment to singlehood compared to males
 - *Conservative report greater investment into singlehood than liberals*

Discussion

- We will test for partial invariance if the current pattern holds
- Future directions include comparing religiosity and sexual orientation across commitment and its predictors, and exploring the characteristics of individuals who are highly committed to singlehood.

Scan for preregistration





Thank you to my collaborators!

Dr. Emily Beauparlant

Dr. Jeewon Oh

Research Assistants from Oh Lab

